Four Chairs

That Look Like They Know Where They Came From

BY GLENN GORDON

One of the most interesting characters ever to make a chair of wood was the late Axel Erlandson, who, by carefully training and grafting the limbs of four saplings planted for the purpose, grew a chair right out of the ground. Judging from a photo of Erlandson seated in the chair at his Tree Circus, a roadside attraction he created outside Santa Cruz, California, he seems to have been an odd duck. That wouldn't make him much different from a lot of other woodworkers, except for one thing: he built with wood that was still alive, whereas most woodworkers build with pieces of trees that are definitely dead, either because lumberjacks killed them, or wind or disease or old age took them down. By the time wood reaches our hands, it's relatively inert. Briskly practical and eager to get on with things, we tend just to regard it as stuff, not as stiffs, and keep consciousness of its origins off to the side.

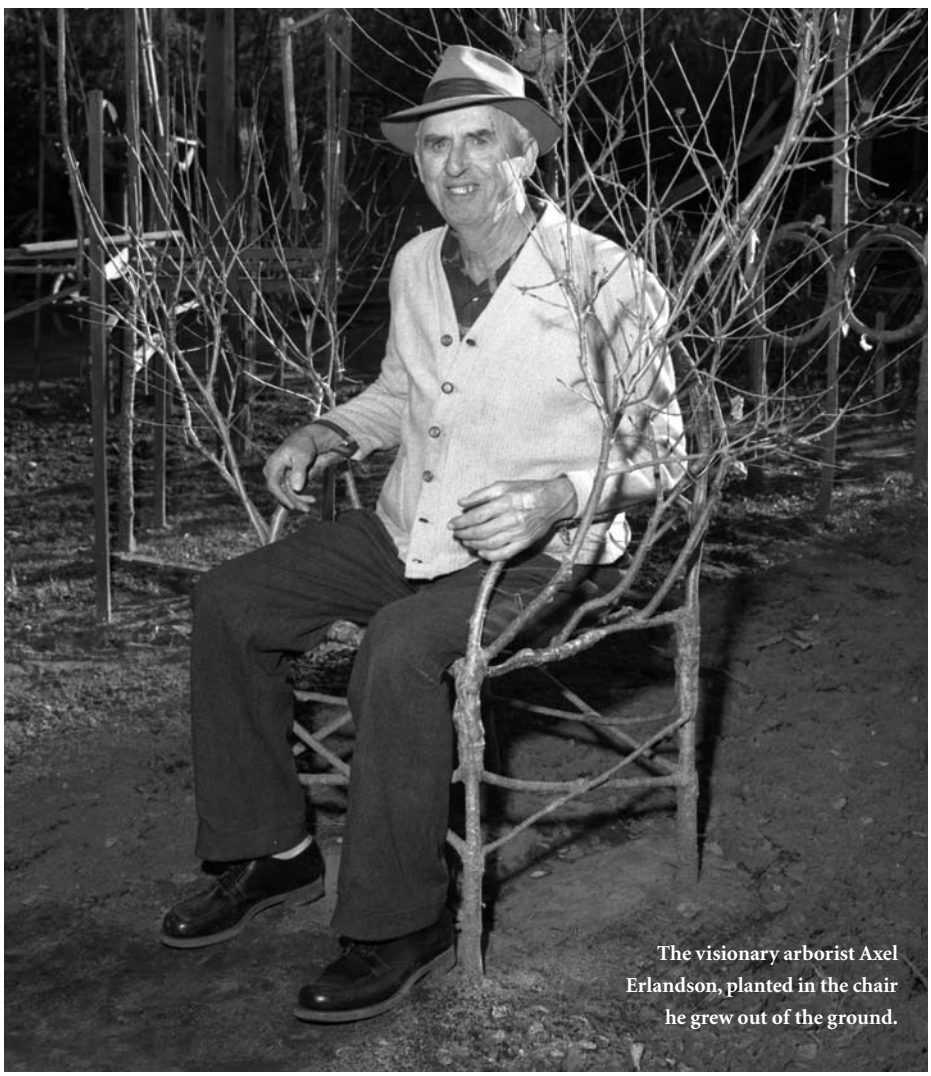


PHOTO BY ED WEBBER, COURTESY OF COVELLO & COVELLO PHOTOGRAPHY

The visionary arborist Axel Erlandson, planted in the chair he grew out of the ground.

But even dead and now dismantled into lumber, pieces of wood assert something about their past life as the flesh of trees. They continue to signal the forces and vectors of their growth. Erlandson, in his strange but tuned-in way, picked up on these signals. He understood how trees behaved…how their trunks and limbs took the forms they took—an understanding most clearly articulated in the statement by the early 20th century British biologist D'Arcy Thompson that "structure is a diagram of forces." Carrying this idea further, you could say that a tree's myriad "decisions" about its growth—which way it will bend, where it will branch— transmigrate to the next stage of its existence, and are in a sense reincarnated in the wood we build with. The wood is dead, but it can still be used in ways expressive of and consonant with nature—nature, more than whim, still being the basis of sound design. This isn't to say that a piece of furniture built of wood has to ape the look of its source tree literally, only that the wood it's made of can continue to embody and express the forces that coursed through that tree. The wood can still speak of what went on in the tree it came from. It's this understanding that informs the designs of the chairs made of wood discussed in this essay. It's integral to what makes them beautiful.

The chairs illustrated here were made by Wharton Esherick, Adrian Ferrazzutti, Stefan Düring, and David Colwell; their structural integrity is immediately readable and understandable. The forces that will act upon them—all the expected stresses and strains—are clearly diagrammed through their forms and expressed without gratuitous ornament. These are living forms, not exercises in empty formality. They have little to do with styles of furniture where, in literal-minded mimicry of nature, the limbs of creatures such as lions, eagles, goats, and dogs seem to have been lopped off and used for the legs and feet of chairs, chests and highboys with fancy pompadours.

I think that what makes me take notice of a chair is the feeling that it sits up and takes notice of me. Each chair here has a



PHOTO BY LEONARD NONES, COURTESY OF LONGHOUSE RESERVE



PHOTO BY SETH JANOFSKY, COURTESY OF DAVE WELTER

Wharton Esherick, "Dining Table and Chair" (1939); hickory, black phenol top, rawhide; table 26½" x 62½" x 40½", chair 32" x 16½" x 15½"; Collection of Jack Lenor Larsen.

Adrian Ferrazzutti, "Arm Chair" (1998); hickory, cowhide, bronze buckles; 34½" x 22½" x 28¾".

stance of animal alertness, a certain readiness— eagerness, almost—to serve its purpose. It's as if each of these chairs is waiting for somebody to come along to make it complete, no chair really being complete until someone sits in it.

The first chair ever to register on me in this way was one of Wharton Esherick's, a side chair made to go with a dining table commissioned for the 1939 World's Fair in New York. Constructed of thin, slightly tapered sticks of hickory, it's all straight lines except for the detail of its filleted joints and the three congruent curved rails of the back. The taut lines of this chair, its joints subtly suggestive of branching, have a vitality that seems generated by the hickory itself. Esherick's understanding of hickory's strength in thin sections enabled him to create a chair visually as light as a line drawing (a printmaker before he became a woodworker, Esherick was known for the beauty of his drawing). Its geometry is much more dynamic—and might also be stronger—than more mundane forms of side chair where all four legs come to the ground more or less vertically. The rear leg is a strut angling emphatically back and down from a point midway along the side of the seat, terminating at the ground in a slightly hoof-like foot that's shaped to strengthen the joint with the low side stretcher. Triangulated with the seat's side rail and the back of the chair, the leg braces the structure against the stress of a person leaning back. It diagrams in a way convincing to the eye the vector of sitting down, showing how forces are delivered to the ground. The side stretchers, so low to the ground, are like rods tensioned with turnbuckles. I don't know if Esherick ever tried dropping these stretchers all the way to the ground—letting them become a pair of skids to give the chair a sled base that could slide on a rug or carpet—but he did build a few variations on his design. Every version is irreducibly light but strong, intuitively engineered with animal feeling for the life in trees, some of them from Esherick's own backyard.

The same feeling that animates Esherick's chairs runs through an armchair by Adrian Ferrazzutti, a former student of James Krenov. The chair's slender frame, also of hickory, follows a structural pattern almost identical (if you discount the arm) to Esherick's, which looks like it might have been its source. Its thin sections similarly exploit hickory's strength (Ferrazzutti also does the chair in wenge, a wood with similar characteristics.) The biggest difference is that Ferrazzutti uses bent laminated curves where Esherick used straight sticks. The curves—the arc of the back leg leaping off the ground to meet the subtly sprung curve of the front leg—are tremendously alive in the way they picture the loads the chair can expect. The arm overlays and simply rests upon the end of the arc, sandwiching it to the top of that bowed front leg in a gesture that reflects your own arm resting upon it. Most of the chair's joinery is through-mortise-and-tenon, the protruding carved ends of the wedged tenons reading like the punctuation of an essay on structure.

I saw Adrian Ferrazzutti's chair some years ago in a gallery in Mendocino but didn't actually sit in it, so I can't testify to the comfort of the leather seat and back slings. The question of comfort leads to a design evolved by the Dutch chairmaker Stefan Düring. Where Adrian Ferrazzutti forms the leaf-spring-like parts of his chairs with bent laminations, Stefan Düring takes an approach novel to those who get wood today only in the form of rectilinear stock from the lumberyard: he gets the major curves of his chairs directly from the trees. Düring works with planks sawn from crooks and crotches whose readymade, structurally sound curves nicely coincide with (and may even be the origins of) parts of his design. Düring also does a lot of steam bending, particularly of wide boards of ash, elm, and beech, to form the backs of his chairs. Sitting in his earlier armchairs, he came to the conclusion that a continuous leather sling for seat and back wouldn't be comfortable enough for the chair he

wanted to build next, an armchair with a relaxed but decidedly regal composure, which he called the "Sfynx" (Dutch for Sphinx), as perfect a name for a piece of furniture as I've ever heard.

Düring's "Sfynx" is so expressive structurally that it seems almost biologically alive. Its stance makes it seem as though it is already its own relaxed inhabitant, and as though it could induce the same aristocratic calm in anyone who were to take a seat in it. The curves of the rear leg, the back, and the front post are like three deft strokes of a brush. The rear leg, in a manner similar to Ferrazzutti's design, springs forward and up to the post with the leap of a cat. Reclining in the chair, your hands rest upon the paws of the "Sfynx," the flared tops of the posts offering themselves also as handgrips to lever yourself out of the throne. The forward reach of those paws counteracts the curve of the back just enough, visually, for some of the energy of the design to face outward and not be all slumped back within itself. The "Sfynx," with its enigmatic equilibrium of alertness and repose, is an embodiment of forces that play in the trunks and limbs of animals and trees.

Similarly, though in a more abstract way, the shapes of the four steam-bent staves of ash that form the back and legs of the ingenious "C10" side chair, by the British woodworker David Colwell, speak of the trees they came from. They started out just as four straight boards, but rippling through them is a feeling that they actually grew in those shapes…their lines simply followed the path of least resistance. Colwell has given close attention in this design to how the structure's circumstances change as forces move along the chair's carefully formed, variably thickening and thinning ribbons of ash. He's studied the working qualities of that ash, which is sawn from young, fast-growing, small-diameter trees, scantlings that yield wood ideal for the chair's design. The wood is resilient but strong, and the trees plentiful, their stock continually replenished through managed forestry in England. The relatively narrow boards cut from these trees are steam-bent (around fixtures pretty much like those shown in photos of Thonet's factory in the late 19th century) with minimum waste of material and energy. Colwell is seriously engaged with the ecology of his locale—his conviction of the necessity of sustainable design is the impetus to everything he builds.

The "C10" is an eloquently minimal design. It makes shrewd use of a material that Colwell values and has therefore decided not to plunder. A work of great structural candor, it lets go of traditional joinery, but not of structural integrity. A simple "spider" of strategically bent steel rods attaches, tensions, and unifies the legs underneath a seat that ties everything together. The thinning necessary to flex the steamed stave through the beautiful curve of the knee of the front leg quotes the way the tight curves on the underside of ash handles on baskets are drawknifed thin. Continuing down, the leg thickens to a shape something like that of the calf of your own leg, getting meatier so as to have enough material to accept the strut that tensions and triangulates the structure. The front legs are canted slightly outward and away from each other so that their axes can converge to form the twin tailbones that attach to the rear legs behind the chair's seat. Finally, there is the line of the rear stave: subtly bending in and out all along its length, nowhere dead-straight—it's like something grown out of the ground. It's had a little help to get it to look that way, but so did the chair that Axel Erlandson grew from saplings. If these chairs all seem alive, it's because the four woodworkers who created them were all conscious of the trees that lend them form.

Glenn Gordon is a writer and photographer living in St. Paul, Minnesota. He can be reached at ggordon22@earthlink.net.



PHOTO BY STEFAN DÜRING

Stefan Düring, "Sfynx" (1989); contour-sawn and steambent ash, upholstered leather stuffed with wool; 27½" x 23⅝" x 27½".



PHOTO COURTESY OF DAVID COLWELL

David Colwell, "C10 Springback Dining Chair" (2004); steam-bent ash, stainless steel rod; 37¾" x 18⅛" x 22".